Qualify three leads - complete text version

You have just come back from a busy industry event where you met dozens of potential customers. Several have since followed up to say they are interested in your company’s cloud solutions. Your manager has asked you to run a quick assessment of three leads, using the Challenges, Authority, Money and Prioritization (CHAMP) model, so that you can decide which to focus on first. You do not have all the details, and some of what you have is partial or vague. That is how qualification usually starts. For each lead, rate each part of the CHAMP model, decide whether the lead is worth pursuing and choose a follow-up question that would close the biggest gap. Then decide which lead to contact first and which to treat lightly. If a choice is not right, the feedback explains why and you can try again. There is no perfect lead. The aim is to understand fit and readiness. The companies and people are fictional. This activity is not scored, and nothing you choose or write is stored or sent anywhere unless you save a text file yourself. Allow about 15 minutes.

How to use this version

You can do every stage on paper or in a document. For each lead, read the profile, then rate Challenges, Authority, Money and Prioritization as a strong signal, weak or uncertain, or missing. Decide whether the lead is worth pursuing and choose the follow-up question you think would close the biggest gap. Then read the feedback for every option and compare it with your choices. If you chose differently, work out why before moving on. After the three leads, choose which to contact first and which to treat lightly.

The CHAMP model

CHAMP helps you judge fit. For each lead, ask four questions.

- Challenges: Is there a problem you can solve?
- Authority: Can this person make or shape the decision?
- Money: Is budget available or likely?
- Prioritization: Is there urgency or a timeline?

Lead 1 of 3: Laconia Energy Systems

Operations manager, Laconia Energy Systems

Renewable energy infrastructure

- The manager’s chief executive officer (CEO) has recently expressed interest in upgrading their production software.

- The operations manager has sign-off responsibility.
- She mentioned that budgets are tight this year but may open up next quarter.
- She is frustrated with delays from current systems but has not clearly outlined return on investment (ROI) expectations.

A. Rate each part of CHAMP

Rate each part of CHAMP using only what the profile tells you. Consider both what is stated and what is implied. Challenges: Is there a problem you can solve? Options: Strong signal; Weak or uncertain; Missing.

- Challenges, Strong signal - Best fit. Feedback: That fits. Delays from current systems are a real, present problem, and the CEO’s interest suggests it is noticed at the top.
- Challenges, Weak or uncertain - Not the best fit. Feedback: Not quite. The profile names a real problem: frustration with delays from current systems. What is vague is the return she expects, which you can still ask about.
- Challenges, Missing - Not the best fit. Feedback: Not quite. A challenge is stated: frustration with delays from current systems.

Authority: Can this person make or shape the decision? Options: Strong signal; Weak or uncertain; Missing.

- Authority, Strong signal - Best fit. Feedback: That fits. The operations manager has sign-off responsibility, which is a direct signal.
- Authority, Weak or uncertain - Not the best fit. Feedback: Not quite. Sign-off responsibility is stated outright, so authority is a strong signal.
- Authority, Missing - Not the best fit. Feedback: Not quite. Authority is stated: the operations manager has sign-off responsibility.

Money: Is budget available or likely? Options: Strong signal; Weak or uncertain; Missing.

- Money, Strong signal - Not the best fit. Feedback: The accepted rating is weak: budgets are tight and may open next quarter. Funding for this purchase is uncertain; the profile does not establish that money is entirely absent.
- Money, Weak or uncertain - Best fit. Feedback: That fits. Budgets are tight this year and may only open next quarter. That is a timing gap, not a ‘no’.
- Money, Missing - Not the best fit. Feedback: Not quite. The profile does say something: budgets are tight now and may open next quarter. That is uncertain, not missing.

Prioritization: Is there urgency or a timeline? Options: Strong signal; Weak or uncertain; Missing.

- Prioritization, Strong signal - Not the best fit. Feedback: Not quite. There are hints about timing, but no stated decision date or urgency.

- Prioritization, Weak or uncertain - Best fit. Feedback: That fits. The CEO’s recent interest and a possible next-quarter budget hint at timing, but nobody has given a decision date or said how urgent this is.
- Prioritization, Missing - Not the best fit. Feedback: Not quite. There are hints, such as the CEO’s recent interest and a possible next-quarter budget, so this is uncertain rather than missing.

B. Decide

Is this lead worth pursuing?

- Pursue now - Not the best fit. Feedback: The activity places this lead below the more urgent follow-up case. A clear problem and sign-off responsibility are promising, but the funding process and timing still need clarification; this is a prioritisation judgement, not a universal rule rejecting unknown budgets.
- Keep warm and probe the gaps - Best fit. Feedback: That fits. A real problem and a person with sign-off justify keeping the lead warm. A delayed budget suggests nurturing, not disqualification, and the gaps tell you what to ask.
- Do not pursue - Not the best fit. Feedback: Not quite. A delayed budget is a timing gap, not a reason to drop a lead that has a real problem and someone with sign-off.

C. Follow up

Which follow-up question would best close the biggest gap?

- “When do you expect budget decisions for next quarter, and what results would you need to see before approving a change?” - Best fit. Feedback: That fits. It goes straight to the biggest gaps: whether and when money opens, and what return she expects, without pressuring her.
- “What solutions are your competitors currently using?” - Not the best fit. Feedback: Not quite. This may give context, but it does not close a gap in qualification.
- “How many employees work in your company?” - Not the best fit. Feedback: Not quite. This is useful background, but it is not tied to the gaps in this profile.

Lead 2 of 3: Anarres Systems

Chief executive officer, Anarres Systems

Software as a service (SaaS) startup with 40 employees, growing fast

- The CEO attended a webinar hosted by your company and signed up for a demo.
- They are currently using a competitor’s solution but struggling with scaling.
- Their latest funding round closed 3 months ago, and they are actively hiring.
- Their timeline to implement new tools is “sometime in the next 12 months.”

A. Rate each part of CHAMP

Rate each part of CHAMP using only what the profile tells you. Consider both what is stated and what is implied. Challenges: Is there a problem you can solve? Options: Strong signal; Weak or uncertain; Missing.

- Challenges, Strong signal - Best fit. Feedback: That fits. Struggling to scale with their current solution is a clear, specific problem.
- Challenges, Weak or uncertain - Not the best fit. Feedback: Not quite. The profile names the problem: they are struggling with scaling on a competitor’s solution.
- Challenges, Missing - Not the best fit. Feedback: Not quite. A challenge is stated: they are struggling with scaling.

Authority: Can this person make or shape the decision? Options: Strong signal; Weak or uncertain; Missing.

- Authority, Strong signal - Best fit. Feedback: That fits the activity’s strong-signal rating: the contact’s senior position suggests influence in this small company. It does not confirm purchase-specific approval authority; establish who can sign off and who else is involved.
- Authority, Weak or uncertain - Not the best fit. Feedback: The accepted rating is strong as an investigation signal: the senior contact may shape the decision. Purchase-specific approval authority is still unconfirmed; ask who can sign off and who else is involved.
- Authority, Missing - Not the best fit. Feedback: The contact’s senior position is stated, so there is an authority signal to investigate. The activity rates that signal strong; actual approval responsibility for this purchase remains to be checked.

Money: Is budget available or likely? Options: Strong signal; Weak or uncertain; Missing.

- Money, Strong signal - Best fit. Feedback: That fits the activity’s strong-signal rating: recent funding and hiring suggest capacity worth investigating. They do not confirm money allocated to this purchase; ask about funding and approval for the proposed project.
- Money, Weak or uncertain - Not the best fit. Feedback: The accepted answer is strong as an investigation signal because the company recently raised funds and is hiring. Allocation for this purchase remains unknown; the rating is not confirmation of an approved budget.
- Money, Missing - Not the best fit. Feedback: Recent funding and hiring are stated capacity signals. The activity rates them strong, while allocation and approval of funds for this particular purchase remain unknown.

Prioritization: Is there urgency or a timeline? Options: Strong signal; Weak or uncertain; Missing.

- Prioritization, Strong signal - Not the best fit. Feedback: Not quite. A window of up to 12 months with no decision date is not urgency.

- Prioritization, Weak or uncertain - Best fit. Feedback: That fits. “Sometime in the next 12 months” is a vague timeline. That is a gap rather than a disqualifier, because the demo sign-up shows current interest.
- Prioritization, Missing - Not the best fit. Feedback: Not quite. A timeline is stated, but it is vague. That makes it uncertain rather than missing.

B. Decide

Is this lead worth pursuing?

- Pursue now - Best fit. Feedback: This case has the highest follow-up priority in the activity: a stated scaling problem and a demo request justify prompt discovery. The strong authority and money ratings are signals to investigate, not confirmation that the opportunity is fully qualified.
- Keep warm and probe the gaps - Not the best fit. Feedback: Keeping contact is useful, but this case’s clear challenge and demo request justify prompt follow-up. Confirm approval responsibility, purchase funding and timing during that follow-up; acting now does not mean the deal is fully qualified.
- Do not pursue - Not the best fit. Feedback: Not quite. A vague timeline is a gap, not a reason to drop a lead with this many strong signals.

C. Follow up

Which follow-up question would best close the biggest gap?

- “What would need to happen for you to decide sooner than 12 months?” - Best fit. Feedback: That fits. The vague timeline is the main gap, and this question asks what would bring the decision forward.
- “Which competitor’s product are you using today?” - Not the best fit. Feedback: Not quite. This may give context, but it does not close the timeline gap.
- “What is your company’s annual revenue?” - Not the best fit. Feedback: Not quite. This is background, not tied to a gap in this profile.

Lead 3 of 3: Dawnstar Diagnostics

Information technology (IT) director, Dawnstar Diagnostics

Healthcare sector, specialising in medical equipment distribution

- The IT director reached out after hearing about your security solutions.
- Their procurement process needs approval from multiple stakeholders and can take 6 to 9 months.
- Budget allocation for cybersecurity was increased this fiscal year.
- No specific urgency has been expressed, so the conversation is mainly exploratory at this stage.

A. Rate each part of CHAMP

Rate each part of CHAMP using only what the profile tells you. Consider both what is stated and what is implied. Challenges: Is there a problem you can solve? Options: Strong signal; Weak or uncertain; Missing.

- Challenges, Strong signal - Not the best fit. Feedback: Not quite. They reached out about security, but no problem or goal has been stated. Interest is not the same as a challenge.
- Challenges, Weak or uncertain - Not the best fit. Feedback: Not quite. Nothing in the profile says what problem they want to solve, only that they reached out. Treat the challenge as missing and ask about it.
- Challenges, Missing - Best fit. Feedback: That fits. Interest in security solutions is not a stated problem. Nobody has said what they are trying to fix.

Authority: Can this person make or shape the decision? Options: Strong signal; Weak or uncertain; Missing.

- Authority, Strong signal - Not the best fit. Feedback: Not quite. Approval needs multiple stakeholders, and the profile does not say what part the IT director plays.
- Authority, Weak or uncertain - Best fit. Feedback: That fits. The IT director reached out, but the decision needs several people’s approval and the profile does not say what part the IT director plays in it.
- Authority, Missing - Not the best fit. Feedback: Not quite. The profile does say something: approval needs multiple stakeholders. What is unclear is the IT director’s role in it.

Money: Is budget available or likely? Options: Strong signal; Weak or uncertain; Missing.

- Money, Strong signal - Best fit. Feedback: That fits the activity’s strong-signal rating. An increased cybersecurity budget is relevant evidence of potential funding capacity; confirm how much, if any, is approved for this proposed purchase.
- Money, Weak or uncertain - Not the best fit. Feedback: The activity treats the stated increase in the relevant budget area as a strong investigation signal. It still does not establish an allocation for a particular supplier or project.
- Money, Missing - Not the best fit. Feedback: The profile does state an increased cybersecurity budget, so the money signal is present. Purchase-specific allocation and approval remain to be confirmed.

Prioritization: Is there urgency or a timeline? Options: Strong signal; Weak or uncertain; Missing.

- Prioritization, Strong signal - Not the best fit. Feedback: Not quite. No urgency has been expressed.
- Prioritization, Weak or uncertain - Best fit. Feedback: That fits. Nobody has expressed urgency, the process can take 6 to 9 months and the conversation is exploratory. Priority is low, which is a signal in itself.

- Prioritization, Missing - Not the best fit. Feedback: Not quite. The profile does tell you something: no urgency and a long process. That is a weak priority, not a missing one.

B. Decide

Is this lead worth pursuing?

- Pursue now - Not the best fit. Feedback: Not quite. With no stated challenge, no urgency and a 6 to 9 month process, heavy effort now would be premature. Budget is the one strong signal.
- Keep warm and probe the gaps - Best fit. Feedback: That fits. Money is the one strong signal and they reached out, so a light follow-up is worthwhile. It is the weakest of the three leads, so it should not take much of your time yet.
- Do not pursue - Not the best fit. Feedback: Not quite. The profile does not show that there is no need. It shows that no need has been stated yet. They reached out and the cybersecurity budget rose, so one probing question is cheap before you let this go.

C. Follow up

Which follow-up question would best close the biggest gap?

- “What business outcomes are you hoping to achieve with this solution?” - Best fit. Feedback: That fits. The biggest gap is that no challenge has been stated, and this question asks for the goal behind the enquiry.
- “Who else will be involved in making this decision?” - Not the best fit. Feedback: Not quite. This is a good question for the authority gap, but the biggest gap is that no challenge has been stated. Ask about the problem first.
- “How many employees work in your company?” - Not the best fit. Feedback: Not quite. This is useful background, but it is not tied to a gap in this profile.

Choose your priorities

Your manager wants to know where your effort should go this week. Use the three assessments you have just completed.

Which lead do you contact first?

- Laconia Energy Systems, Operations manager - Not the best fit. Feedback: Not quite. Laconia has a real problem and a person with sign-off, but money may not open until next quarter, so a first call now would mostly be about keeping the lead warm.
- Anarres Systems, Chief executive officer - Best fit. Feedback: That fits. Anarres has three strong signals and has asked for a demo. It is the most qualified lead and the one most ready for a conversation.

- Dawnstar Diagnostics, Information technology (IT) director - Not the best fit. Feedback: Not quite. Dawnstar is the weakest of the three, with no stated challenge, no urgency and a long procurement process.

Which lead gets the lightest touch for now?

- Laconia Energy Systems, Operations manager - Not the best fit. Feedback: Not quite. Laconia has a stated problem and a person with sign-off. Keep it warm with regular contact until the budget picture is clear.
- Anarres Systems, Chief executive officer - Not the best fit. Feedback: Not quite. Anarres is the most qualified lead and should not get the lightest touch.
- Dawnstar Diagnostics, Information technology (IT) director - Best fit. Feedback: That fits. Dawnstar has no stated challenge, no urgency and a 6 to 9 month process. A light check-in with one probing question is enough for now.

Reflect and save

Here is your assessment of all three leads. Notice that none of them was perfect, and that the gaps told you what to ask next.

- Laconia Energy Systems: Challenges strong signal; Authority strong signal; Money weak or uncertain; Prioritization weak or uncertain. Decision: Keep warm and probe the gaps.
- Anarres Systems: Challenges strong signal; Authority strong signal; Money strong signal; Prioritization weak or uncertain. Decision: Pursue now.
- Dawnstar Diagnostics: Challenges missing; Authority weak or uncertain; Money strong signal; Prioritization weak or uncertain. Decision: Keep warm and probe the gaps.

Choose one gap you would try to close first, and say why. How would closing it change your decision about that lead? In the interactive version, Save my assessment downloads your three assessments, your priorities and your reflection as a text file. An empty reflection prompts: Write a short reflection before saving. Qualification starts with incomplete information. Spotting both the signals and the gaps tells you where to focus your effort, and where to ask the next question.